

Unit III: PUBLICATION ETHICS

Publication ethics: definition, introduction and importance - Best practices / standards setting initiatives and guidelines: COPE, WAME, etc. - Conflicts of interest - Publication misconduct: definition, concept, problems that lead to unethical behaviour and vice versa, types - Violation of publication ethics, authorship and contributor ship - Identification of publication misconduct, complaints and appeals - Predatory publisher and journals.

1. Publication Ethics

Ethical standards for publication exist to ensure high-quality scientific publications, public trust in scientific findings, and that people receive credit for their work and ideas.

The **Committee on Publication Ethics (COPE)** is an international forum for editors and publishers of peer-reviewed journals that provide the **code of conduct** and **best practice guidelines** that define publication ethics and advises editors on how to handle cases of research and publication misconduct. In this editorial, we introduce concepts collectively called **publication ethics** including statutory and ethics approval, informed consent, data manipulation and research fraud, plagiarism, simultaneous submission, duplicate publication, self-citation, consent to reproduce published material, ethics of authorship, and conflicts of interest. It is important to avoid the following

Data fabrication and falsification:

Data fabrication means the researcher did not actually do the study, but faked the data. Data falsification means the researcher did the experiment, but then changed some of the data.

Plagiarism:

Taking the ideas and work of other scientists without giving them credit is unfair and dishonest. Copying even one sentence from someone else's manuscript, or even one of your own that has previously been published, without proper citation is considered plagiarism—use your own words instead.

Multiple submissions:

It is unethical to submit the same manuscript to more than one journal at the same time. Doing this wastes the time of editors and peer reviewers, and can damage the reputation of the authors and the journals if published in more than one journal as the later publication will have to be retracted.

Redundant publications (or 'salami' publications):

This means publishing many very similar manuscripts based on the same experiment. Combining your results into one very robust paper is more likely to be of interest to a selective journal. Editors are likely to reject a weak paper that they suspect is a result of salami slicing.

Improper author contribution or attribution:

All listed authors must have made a significant scientific contribution to the research in the manuscript and approved all its claims. Don't forget to list everyone who made a significant scientific contribution, including students and laboratory technicians. Do not "gift" authorship to those who did not contribute to the paper. The International Committee of Medical Journal Editors has detailed guidelines on authorship that are useful for scientists in all fields: International Committee of Medical Journal Editors.

Many journals have tools and processes in place to identify researchers that engage in unethical behavior. If you are caught your manuscript may be rejected without review and your institution informed.

Publication Ethics Checklist	
Approval and Consent	• Do you have approval of the relevant Regulatory Authorities, Institutional Review Board and Ethics Committee? • Have you registered your clinical trial? • Have you documented Informed Consent?
Data Accuracy Falsification Fabrication	• Is there manipulation of material, equipment, process or data? • Have you double-checked data for accuracy? Is there any lurking fake data?
Plagiarism and Self-Plagiarism	• Have you used your own prior work or copied others' work? • If so, have you cited these correctly? • Do you have written permission for reproduced material, figures or tables?
Submission Fraud	Is there simultaneous submission to two journals? Have you published the entire work or part of it (salami-slicing) already? Have you excessively cited your own publications?
Ethics of Authorship	• Have you included all the authors in a specific pre-agreed order? • Do you have an agreement with co-authors? • Are the co-authors aware of the contents of the publication? • Have they had access to, and hold themselves responsible for the data and its interpretation? • Is there is any Ghost Author or a "Guest Author"?
Conflict of Interest	Have you declared relevant interests and relationships that could be seen as influencing your findings (whether financial or scientific)?

Importance of Ethics

There are several reasons why it is important to adhere to ethical norms in research.

First, norms promote the aims of research, such as knowledge, truth, and avoidance of error. For example, prohibitions against fabricating, falsifying, or misrepresenting research data promote the truth and minimize error.

Second, since research often involves a great deal of cooperation and coordination among many different people in different disciplines and institutions, ethical standards promote the **values that are essential to collaborative work**, such as trust, accountability, mutual respect, and fairness. For example, many ethical norms in research, such as guidelines for authorship, copyright and patenting policies, data sharing policies, and confidentiality rules in peer review, are designed to protect intellectual property interests while encouraging collaboration. Most

researchers want to receive credit for their contributions and do not want to have their ideas stolen or disclosed prematurely.

Third, many of the ethical norms help to ensure that researchers can be held **accountable to the public**. For instance, federal policies on research misconduct, conflicts of interest, the human subjects protections, and animal care and use are necessary in order to make sure that researchers who are funded by public money can be held accountable to the public.

Fourth, ethical norms in research also help to build **public support** for research. People are more likely to fund a research project if they can trust the quality and integrity of research.

Finally, many of the norms of research promote a variety of other important **moral and social values**, such as social responsibility, human rights, animal welfare, compliance with the law, and public health and safety. Ethical lapses in research can significantly harm human and animal subjects, students, and the public. For example, a researcher who fabricates data in a clinical trial may harm or even kill patients, and a researcher who fails to abide by regulations and guidelines relating to radiation or biological safety may jeopardize his health and safety or the health and safety of staff and students.

Ethical Principles

Honesty	Objectivity	Integrity	Carefulness
Openness	Transparency	Accountability	Intellectual property
Confidentiality	Social Responsibility	Non-discrimination	Competence

2. Best practices / standards setting initiatives and guidelines : COPE & WAME

a) COMMITTEE ON PUBLICATION ETHICS (COPE)

Guidelines On Good Publication Practice'

COPE was founded in 1997 to address breaches of research and publication ethics. A voluntary body providing a discussion forum and advice for scientific editors, it aims to find practical ways of dealing with the issues, and to develop good practice.

Intellectual honesty should be actively encouraged in all medical and scientific courses of study, and used to inform publication ethics and prevent misconduct. It is with that in mind that these guidelines have been produced.

The guidelines were developed from a preliminary version drafted by individual members of the committee, which was then submitted to extensive consultation. They address: study design and ethical approval, data analysis, authorship, conflict of interests, the peer review process, redundant publication, plagiarism, duties of editors, media relations, advertising, and how to deal with misconduct.

These guidelines are intended to be advisory rather than prescriptive, and to evolve over time. We hope that they will be disseminated widely, endorsed by editors, and refined by those who use them.

1. Study design and ethical approval

Good research should be well justified, well planned, appropriately designed, and ethically approved. To conduct research to a lower standard may constitute misconduct.

2. Data analysis

Data should be appropriately analysed, but inappropriate analysis does not necessarily amount to misconduct. Fabrication and falsification of data do constitute misconduct.

3. Authorship

There is no universally agreed definition of authorship, although attempts have been made. As a minimum, authors should take responsibility for a particular section of the study.

4. Conflicts of interest

Conflicts of interest comprise those which may not be fully apparent and which may influence the judgment of author, reviewers, and editors. They have been described as those which, when revealed later, would make a reasonable reader feel misled or deceived.

They may be personal, commercial, political, academic or financial.

“Financial” interests may include employment, research funding, stock or share ownership, payment for lectures or travel, consultancies and company support for staff.

5. Peer review

Peer reviewers are external experts chosen by editors to provide written opinions, with the aim of improving the study.

Working methods vary from journal to journal, but some use open procedures in which the name of the reviewer is disclosed, together with the full or “edited” report.

6 Redundant publication

Redundant publication occurs when two or more papers, without full cross reference, share the same hypothesis, data, discussion points, or conclusions.

7 Plagiarism

Plagiarism ranges from the unreferenced use of others’ published and unpublished ideas, including research grant applications to submission under “new” authorship of a complete paper, sometimes in a different language. It may occur at any stage of planning, research, writing, or publication: it applies to print and electronic versions.

8 Duties of editors

Editors are the stewards of journals. They usually take over their journal from the previous editor(s) and always want to hand over the journal in good shape.

Most editors provide direction for the journal and build a strong management team.

They must consider and balance the interests of many constituents, including readers, authors, staff, owners, editorial board members, advertisers and the media.

9 Media relations

Medical research findings are of increasing interest to the print and broadcast media. Journalists may attend scientific meetings at which preliminary research findings are presented, leading to their premature publication in the mass media.

10 Advertising

Many scientific journals and meetings derive significant income from advertising.

b) WAME – World Association of Medical Editors

Medical journals aspire to select, through peer review, the highest quality science. To achieve this, the entire peer review and publication process must be thorough, objective, and fair. Almost every aspect of this process involves important ethical principles and decisions, which are seldom explicitly stated and even less often shared with the important readership. Journals' reputations depend on the trust of readers, authors, researchers, reviewers, editors, patients, research subjects, funding agencies, and administrators of public health policy. This trust is enhanced by describing research as explicitly as possible the journal's policies to ensure the ethical treatment of all participants in the publication process.

A comprehensive policy on publication ethics is summarized in this article, which addresses all the major areas of ethics we believe contemporary science journals should consider. Our aim is to encourage editors of journals to use these to develop such policies for their journals and make them accessible to their constituents by publishing them in print or on the web. The document makes recommendations on what we consider to be the best solutions to address these ethical problems, but we expect individual journals to customize the policies to best fit their own situations. However, we believe that every journal should have an explicit policy on each of these issues, and that these policies should be published in each journal so they are accessible to readers, authors, and reviewers.

- Conflict of Interest in Peer-Reviewed Medical Journals
- Study Design and Ethics
- Authorship
- Peer Review
- Editorial Decisions
- Originality, Prior Publication, and Media Relations
- Plagiarism
- Advertising
- Responding to Allegations of Possible Misconduct
- Relation of the Journal to the Sponsoring Society (if applicable)

3. Conflicts of Interest(COI)

All manuscripts for articles, original research reports, editorials, comments, reviews, book reviews, and letters that are submitted to the journal must be accompanied by a conflict of interest disclosure statement or a declaration by the authors that they do not have any conflicts of interest to declare. All articles that are published in the journal must be accompanied by this conflict of interest disclosure statement or a statement that the authors have replied that they have no conflicts of interest to declare. If a journal prints unsigned editorials, they should not have been written by anyone with a conflict of interest.

To facilitate this policy, all authors must privately disclose 'ALL their potential conflicts of interest' to the editors of the journal at the time of submission. These include all financial and non-financial interests and relationships, direct employment with a private sector entity, and service on private sector and non-profit Boards and advisory panels, whether paid or unpaid. Authors should also disclose any conflict of interest that may have influenced either the conduct or the presentation of the research to the editors, including but not limited to close relationships with those who might be helped or hurt by the publication, academic interests and rivalries, and any personal, religious or political convictions relevant to the topic at hand.

In the article, the authors must include a draft statement that discloses all relevant conflicts of interest and affiliations. The relevance of financial conflicts of interest with private firms is defined as a relationship of any value with a firm that has a stake in the subject of the manuscript or its competitors. Relevance for patents is defined as any invention or pending invention connected in any way to the subject. As relevance is often in the eye of the beholder, one must err on the side of full disclosure when drafting the disclosure statement. Editors will check a draft against the private financial disclosure statement and initiate discussions toward possible adjustments, if necessary.

Non-Financial Conflicts of Interest:

Authors may have strong views about the article being submitted for publication. The authors must consider disclosing these views and the editors may choose to print any affiliations or expressions from these views that may be relevant. These may be personal, political or intellectual, and may include any expression of strongly held views relevant to the subject of submission. Such disclosures may be original or they may be references to opinions previously expressed in books or monographs, opposite editorials or public comments, or to some prior sworn testimony or lobbying of legislators or legislative bodies. Disclosable non-financial conflicts of interest will also include membership or affiliation to nongovernmental organizations that have an interest in the submission.

How do I Make a Declaration?

If you are submitting your article for publishing in a journal that requires you to make a 'Declaration of Conflicting Interests', please include such a declaration at the end of your manuscript, following any acknowledgments and prior to the references, under the heading 'Conflict of Interest Statement'. If no declaration is made, the following will be printed under this heading in your article: 'None Declared'. Alternatively, you may wish to state that 'The author(s) declare(s) that there is no conflict of interest'.

4. Publication Misconduct

To respect the intellectual property rights of others and uphold the standards for academic publishing, publishers of book or journal is adopting a zero tolerance policy towards papers associated with publication misconduct. Publication misconduct includes plagiarism, fabrication, falsification, inappropriate authorship, duplicate submission/multiple submissions, overlapping publication, and salami publication.

1.Plagiarism: Plagiarism is the appropriation of another person's thoughts, ideas, data, figures, research methods, or words without giving appropriate credit, or the over-citation of another person's published work.

2. Fabrication: Fabrication is the practice of making up data or results without having performed relevant research.

3. Falsification: Falsification is the practice of changing data or results intentionally such that misleading conclusion is drawn.

4. Inappropriate authorship: Authorship is not appropriately assigned based on the author's contributions.

5. Duplicate submission/multiple submissions: Duplicate submission/multiple submissions refers to practice of submitting the same manuscript or several manuscripts with minor differences (e.g., differences only in title, keywords, abstract, author order, author affiliations, or a small

amount of text) to two or more journals at the same time, or submitting to another journal within an agreed or stipulated period.

6. Overlapping publication: Overlapping publication refers to the practice of publishing a paper overlaps substantially with one already published.

7. Salami publication: Salami publication refers to the practice of slicing data from a large study, could have been reported in a single paper, into different pieces and publishing them in two or more articles, all of which cover the same population, methods, and question.

8. Inappropriate authorship: Authorship is not appropriately assigned based on the author's contributions.

5. Violation of Publication Ethics. Authorship and Contributorship

Authorship and Contributorship

Naming authors on a scientific paper ensures that the appropriate individuals get credit, and are accountable, for the research. Deliberately misrepresenting a scientist's relationship to their work is considered to be a form of misconduct that undermines confidence in the reporting of the work itself.

While there is no universal definition of authorship, an "author" is generally considered to be an individual who has made a significant intellectual contribution to the study.

According to the guidelines for authorship established by the International Committee of Medical Journal Editors (ICMJE), "All persons designated as authors should qualify for authorship, and all those who qualify should be listed."

Four criteria must all be met to be credited as an author:

- Substantial contribution to the study conception and design, data acquisition, analysis, and interpretation.
- Drafting or revising the article for intellectual content.
- Approval of the final version.
- Agreement to be accountable for all aspects of the work related to the accuracy or integrity of any part of the work.

The following are some general guidelines, which may vary from field to field:

- The order of authorship should be "a joint decision of the coauthors".
- Individuals who are involved in a study but don't satisfy the journal's criteria for authorship, should be listed as "Contributors" or "Acknowledged Individuals". Examples include: assisting the research by providing advice, providing research space, departmental oversight, and obtaining financial support.
- For large, multi-center trials, the list of clinicians and centers is typically published, along with a statement of the individual contributions made. Some groups list authors alphabetically, sometimes with a note to explain that all authors made equal contributions to the study and the publication.

Three types of authorship are considered unacceptable:

- "Ghost" authors, who contribute substantially but are not acknowledged (often paid by commercial sponsors);
- "Guest" authors, who make no discernible contributions, but are listed to help increase the chances of publication;

- "Gift" authors, whose contribution is based solely on a tenuous affiliation with a study.

When not appropriately addressed, authorship issues can lead to dispute. Some disputes are based on misconduct (such as lying about one's role); some stem from questions of interpretation, such as the degree to which a person's contribution can be considered "substantial," and if authorship is justified.

Other potential issues could include: being involved in a study, but not listed as an author or contributor; someone taking your idea and publishing a paper claiming full authorship; and finding your name on a publication without your permission.

If a complaint is filed over a dispute, an investigation may be conducted with the journal editor and author's institution to reach a resolution.

Because of the potential for ambiguity and confused expectations, it is strongly advised that before the research begins, a meeting take place to document how each person will be acknowledged.

Issues around authorship can be complex and sensitive. Early career researchers who encounter such situations may fear they will jeopardize their reputation and career if they speak up. Take the time to fully understand each journal's guidelines for authorship, and industry requirements. If you find yourself in a challenging situation that you are not sure how to handle, consult with a trusted mentor or supervisor.

6. Identification of publication misconduct, complaints and appeals

The following are the problems classified as misconduct of publication

- Plagiarism • Text recycling ('self-plagiarism')
- Duplicate/redundant publication
- Authorship issues
- Disputes, gift authorship, ghost authorship
- Data fabrication/falsification
- Image manipulation
- Undisclosed competing interests
- Lack of ethics approval – animal or human
- Unethical treatment of participants
- Lack of consent

How to Handle Reviewer Misconduct

Reviewer misconduct can range from minor issues, such as rude or unconstructive reviews, to major issues, such as the appropriation of author's ideas or data.

As an editor, you entrust reviewers with a high level of responsibility. They are given access to privileged information (i.e. unpublished research) and their recommendations can sway the publication outcome. Unfortunately, there are rare occasions when that trust is misplaced.

Minor problems are relatively easy to respond to. Delete rude comments, and don't invite reviewers again if they supply poor quality, late, or unconstructive reviews.

There may be other instances where editors receive complaints from authors about reviewer misconduct. We outline approaches to these instances below.

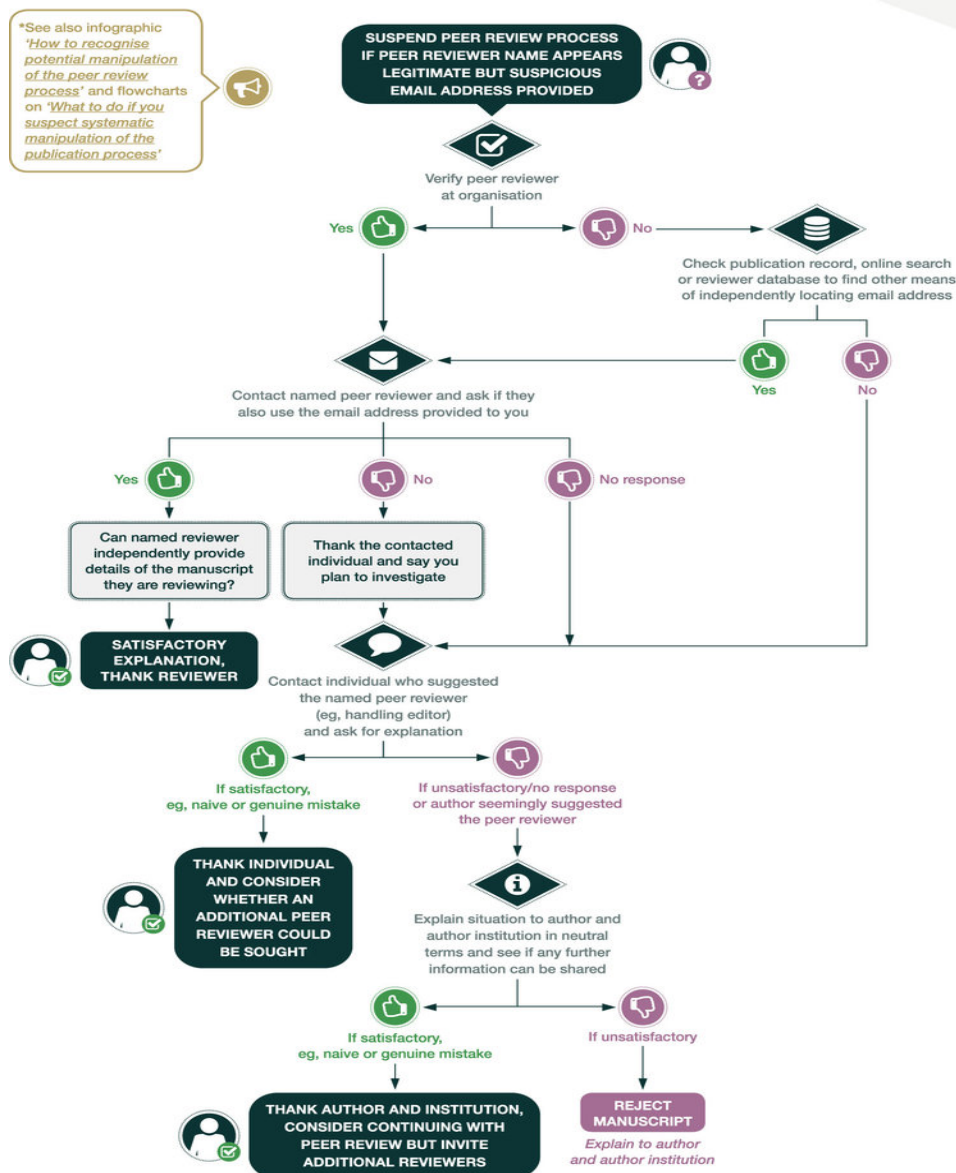


Fig : COPE Flowchart

Appeals

Following the rejection of a paper, the author may appeal to the editor. Your journal should have a clear appeals policy stating under what circumstances an appeal will be considered and how the appeal process will be handled.

Conflicts of Interest

One issue authors might raise during an appeal for reviewer misconduct is bias due to conflict of interests. If your journal operates open peer review, the author will know the identity of the reviewer and can specify the potential conflict of interests. For journals operating single or double blind peer review, accusations of bias are likely to be suppositional rather than substantiated, but should still be given careful consideration.

Appeals can often be resolved by getting a second opinion. Engaging a new reviewer will eliminate the potential alleged bias. It is difficult in these cases to evidence malicious intent on behalf of a reviewer, but you retain the right not to use reviewers who you feel are unable to give an objective assessment.

Appropriated Data

Another possible complaint of reviewer misconduct concerns the alleged appropriation of data during the review process. An author may raise a complaint if they discover their ideas or data are used in a published paper. They may conclude that these can only have been appropriated during the review process. These issues can be complicated because there is likely to be some time lag between the review process conducted at your journal and the publication of the appropriated data.

Because complaints may involve another journal and another editorial team, it's best to make sure you keep them informed. We recommend following the steps outlined in the **COPE Flowcharts**.

7. Predatory publisher and journals

Predatory publishing, sometimes called write-only publishing or deceptive publishing, is an exploitative academic publishing business model that involves charging publication fees to authors without checking articles for quality and legitimacy and without providing editorial and publishing services that legitimate academic journals provide, whether open access or not. They are regarded as predatory because scholars are tricked into publishing with them, although some authors may be aware that the journal is poor quality or even fraudulent. New scholars from developing countries are said to be especially at risk of being misled by predatory publishers. According to one study, 60% of articles published in predatory journals receive no citations over the five-year period following publication.

Complaints that are associated with predatory open-access publishing include:

- Accepting articles quickly with little or no peer review or quality control, including hoax and nonsensical papers.
- Notifying academics of article fees only after papers are accepted.
- Aggressively campaigning for academics to submit articles or serve on editorial boards.
- Listing academics as members of editorial boards without their permission, and not allowing academics to resign from editorial boards.
- Appointing fake academics to editorial boards.
- Mimicking the name or web site style of more established journals.
- Making misleading claims about the publishing operation, such as a false location.
- Using ISSNs improperly.
- Citing fake or non-existent impact factors.
- Boasting about being "indexed" by academic social networking sites (like ResearchGate) and standard identifiers (like ISSNs and DOIs) as if they were prestigious or reputable bibliographic databases.

Predatory publishers have also been compared to vanity presses.

Predatory publishers

- Prioritize self-interest at the expense of scholarship
- Deviate from best editorial and publication practices
- Use indiscriminate solicitation practices (repeated e-mails)

How to identify predatory publishers?

- | | | |
|------------------|----------------------|----------------|
| • Author Fees | No quality check | No ISSN or DOI |
| • No Peer Review | No Ethical Approvals | |